THE LEVEL FIELD
Admissions Intelligence Series

QUEEN ELIZABETH'S SCHOOL

Admissions Blueprint

Examination Mechanics and the Meritocratic Reality

192	3,000+	240+
Places Available	Candidates Sitting	Safe Score Target

Contents

01 The Pure Meritocracy: How Places Are Allocated 3
02 The Score Reality: What the Numbers Actually Mean 4
03 Examination Structure and Time Pressure 5
04 The English Paper: Format and Strategy 6
05 Mathematics: Standardisation and the Guess Quota 7

What This Document Is For

Most admissions guides describe the process. This one describes the mechanics behind it. The distinction matters because the QE examination is not simply a test of ability: it is a test of whether a candidate has been prepared for this specific format, at this specific score threshold, with this specific allocation model.

Each section below addresses one layer of the examination system. Read them in order. The strategic directives in Sections 04 and 05 are only meaningful once Sections 01 to 03 have established why standard preparation is insufficient.

> *"Academic precision is the sole metric for entry. Location, proximity, and circumstance are irrelevant."*

01 How Places Are Allocated

The Pure Meritocracy

Queen Elizabeth's School allocates exactly 192 places annually, awarded strictly in order of examination score with no geographic, social, or circumstantial weighting of any kind.

192

PLACES PER YEAR

Every one of these places is awarded to the highest-scoring candidates, in descending order of standardised score. There are no reserved places, no local catchment adjustments, and no discretionary admissions.

THE FACT

There is no geographic prioritisation, catchment zone, or local advantage built into the QE admissions model. A candidate residing 50 miles from the school with the higher score will unconditionally receive the offer over a candidate living adjacent to the building with the lower score.

THE IMPLICATION

Candidates are competing on a national scale, not a local one. The relevant comparison is not the neighbouring child: it is the highest-scoring candidates across the entire applicant pool. The only variable that determines the outcome is the standardised examination score.

A. THE DISTANCE TIE-BREAKER

Geographic distance from the school is referenced in the admissions policy in one specific and narrow circumstance only:

- If two or more candidates achieve the exact same boundary score for the final available place or places, the candidate residing physically closer to the school is awarded the offer.
- This scenario is statistically rare. In practice, the tie-breaker mechanism is almost never triggered because the examination is designed to produce a distribution of scores rather than clusters of identical results.

Do not factor geography into preparation planning. It is not a competitive variable.

02 What the Numbers Actually Mean

The Score Reality

Over 3,000 candidates compete for 192 places. The official eligibility threshold is not the competitive threshold. Understanding the difference is the most important single piece of information in this document.

3,000+

CANDIDATES COMPETING

For 192 places. This produces a competition ratio of approximately 16 to 1. At this ratio, being 'good enough' to sit the examination is meaningless. The only relevant question is whether the candidate can score in the top 6 to 7 percent of all sitters.

The Three Score Thresholds

The table below translates the official eligibility language into operational reality. The distinction between these three thresholds is the difference between being on a waiting list and holding an unconditional offer on March 1st.

Score Threshold	What It Means	Reality
220 combined SAS	Eligible for consideration	Waitlist only — no guaranteed offer
235 to 238 combined SAS	Strong offer territory	High probability of March 1st offer
240+ combined SAS	Safe score target	Unconditional offer highly likely

B. THE ELIGIBILITY ILLUSION

The official admissions literature states that a combined Standardised Age Score of 220 makes a candidate 'eligible to be considered.' This language is technically accurate and operationally misleading in equal measure.

- Achieving 220 does not produce an offer. It places the candidate on a waiting list.
- Waiting list movement is unpredictable and historically insufficient to convert most 220-band candidates into offer-holders.
- The 220 threshold should be treated as the minimum score required to sit near the bottom of the competition, not as a target.

Actionable directive: Disregard the 220 threshold entirely. Set all mock examination targets to a baseline of 240. This is the score that produces unconditional offers with high statistical reliability.

03 Format, Papers, and the Time Constraint

Examination Structure and Time Pressure

The QE examination uses bespoke GL Assessment formats. Two multiple-choice papers are taken consecutively on the same day. Understanding the time arithmetic of each paper is as important as the subject knowledge it tests.

PAPER 1: ENGLISH

- **Duration:** 50 minutes
- **Questions:** Approximately 60 -70 questions
- **Per Question:** Under 50 seconds available
- **Content:** Two reading passages plus a SPaG section

PAPER 2: MATHEMATICS

- **Duration:** 50 minutes
- **Questions:** Approximately 50-60 questions
- **Per Question:** Under 60 seconds available
- **Content:** Multi-step problems scaled to separate top percentiles

The core constraint

Depth of knowledge is necessary but not sufficient. A candidate who spends three minutes on a single difficult question has, in the same moment, failed to answer four or five standard questions elsewhere on the paper. Velocity and time discipline are equal in importance to subject competence.

- Under 50 seconds per English question. Under 60 seconds per Maths question.
- Any question that exceeds its time allowance by more than 15 seconds must be guessed and abandoned immediately.
- Time management is not a soft skill in this examination. It is a scored mechanical variable.

04 Format Anomaly and Strategic Execution

The English Paper

The 50-minute English paper deviates from standard 11+ formats in a specific and consequential way. Understanding the deviation is what makes the strategic response to it possible.

A. THE DUAL-TEXT FORMAT

Most 11+ English papers use a single reading passage. The QE English paper deploys two distinct passages in the following order:

- A dense, archaic 19th-century literary extract, typically fiction with complex syntax and unfamiliar vocabulary.
- A modern analytical non-fiction piece, typically an article or report with a different register and purpose.
- A Spelling, Punctuation, and Grammar section, typically 15 to 20 questions on objective grammatical rules.

The danger: Processing the archaic first passage depletes cognitive capacity before the candidate reaches the most objective and most reliably scorable section of the paper: the SPaG questions.

The Strategic Response

The standard approach of working through the paper chronologically from question one is incorrect for this format. The structure of the paper rewards candidates who execute sections in a non-chronological order.

1

Navigate to SPaG First

- The moment the timer starts, turn to the final pages of the paper and begin the SPaG section.
- Complete all 15 to 20 SPaG questions within the first 8 to 10 minutes of the examination.
- SPaG questions test objective grammatical rules. Right or wrong answers do not depend on interpretation. They are the most reliably scorable questions on the paper.

Note: These marks must be secured at peak cognitive capacity, not after twenty minutes of processing archaic Victorian prose.

2

Return to the Passages with Remaining Time

- After completing SPaG, return to question one and work through both reading passages with the remaining 40 minutes.
- The time allocation is now reversed from the standard approach: the difficult passage is approached after objective marks are already banked, not before.
- Apply scan mode for factual retrieval questions and intensive mode for inference and language questions.

Why this matters for the final score

The SPaG section is the highest-certainty marks on the English paper. A grammatical rule is either applied correctly or not: there is no ambiguity, no inference, and no interpretation required. Securing these marks first and saving the

analytical reading for the remainder of the time is the highest-return time management decision available on this paper.

05 Standardisation, Raw Scores, and the Guess Quota

Mathematics

GL Assessment applies an age-standardisation algorithm to raw scores. Zero negative marking is applied. Understanding both of these mechanics changes the correct approach to time-pressured questions significantly.

80–85%

RAW SCORE REQUIRED

To achieve a standardised score in the 238+ range that reliably produces an offer. Scoring 100% is statistically unnecessary, mathematically unlikely, and not the correct target. The examination is designed to separate candidates at the top: attempting every question perfectly is a lower-scoring strategy than completing 85% accurately and intelligently managing the rest.

A. THE ZERO NEGATIVE MARKING RULE

An incorrect answer and a blank answer both yield exactly zero marks. There is no penalty for guessing.

- This rule has a direct and specific strategic implication that most candidates are not told explicitly.
- Leaving a question blank is never the correct decision. A blank answer produces zero marks with certainty. A guess on a five-option multiple-choice question produces a 20% probability of a correct mark.
- On four to six genuinely impossible questions per paper, a blind guess is the correct move. It costs nothing and has a non-zero probability of gaining a mark.

The Two Strategic Protocols

1

The 15-Second Abort Rule

- For any multi-step Mathematics problem, the candidate has 15 seconds to identify the logical path to the solution.
- If the method is not clear within 15 seconds, the question must be abandoned immediately.
- Mark a guess on the answer sheet, circle the question number, and move forward.
- If time permits at the end of the paper, return to circled questions. If not, the guess stands.

Note: Perfectionism is the primary cause of low standardisation scores in high-ability candidates. The 15-second rule is not optional.

2

The Guess Quota

- Before the examination begins, the candidate must internalise the following: there will be 4 to 6 questions on this paper that are genuinely beyond their current ability. This is by design.
- These questions exist to separate the top 1% from the top 5%. They are not intended to be solved by the majority of high-scoring candidates.

- The correct response to an impossible question is to bubble a consistent answer (for example, always choosing option C on the mark sheet) and move on within 20 seconds.
- Four minutes spent on one impossible question is four minutes that could have produced five standard marks elsewhere.

The correct score target

Do not target 100%. Target 240 combined SAS. These are different objectives that require different strategies. A candidate targeting perfection will slow down, spend too long on impossible questions, and produce a lower standardised score than a candidate targeting 240 with intelligent time management.

- Target 240 combined SAS across both papers.
- Accept that 4 to 6 questions per paper will be guessed. This is planned, not a failure.
- Every question on the paper is worth one mark. Allocate time accordingly.